



Translation Team

PROFESSIONAL CLUB

Translation Handbook

A beginner's guide to Arabic–English translation

دليل الترجمة

مرشد للمبتدئين في الترجمة بين العربية والإنجليزية

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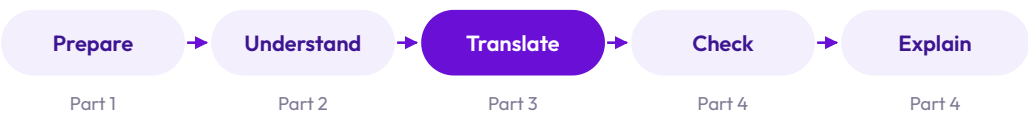
How to use this handbook

كيف تستخدم هذا الدليل

This handbook is for **beginners**. It explains the basics of translating between English and Arabic, one step at a time.

The order of the book

The chapters follow the order in which a translator actually works:



Part 5 introduces useful tools and text types. Part 6 gives you exercises, with answers.

How each chapter works

Every chapter has the same simple layout, so you always know where to look:

- 1. **Introduction:** what you will learn.
- 2. **Key terms:** the main words, with their Arabic equivalents.
- 3. **Explanation:** short sections with examples.
- 4. **Remember:** the most important points.

Signs used in this book

EN → AR	English source text, Arabic translation
AR → EN	Arabic source text, English translation
✓ and ✗	A good translation and a poor translation
SL / TL	Source language / target language (اللغة المصدر / اللغة الهدف)
ST / TT	Source text / target text (النص المصدر / النص الهدف)

Chapter 1

What is translation?

ما الترجمة؟

This chapter explains what translation is and why meaning matters more than words.

Key terms

Translation	الترجمة التحريرية	Transferring the meaning of a written text into another language.
Interpretation	الترجمة الشفهية	Transferring spoken language into another language.
Communication	التواصل	Understanding and being understood.

1.1 Translation carries meaning

A translator does not replace words one by one. A translator carries the **meaning** of a text from one language to another, so that a reader in the other language understands it.

So translation is a kind of **communication between two languages**. If the reader does not understand the translation, it has failed.

1.2 Translation is approximation

No two languages match perfectly. The translator's job is to bring the meaning **as close as possible** to the target language, especially its cultural meaning (Chapter 12).

1.3 The translator in the middle

The author writes for readers of one language. The translator reads the text, understands it, and rewrites it for readers of another language.



REMEMBER

- Translate the **meaning**, not the words.
- Always think about the **reader**.

Chapter 2

The translator

المترجم

This chapter describes the skills a translator needs and the two ways a translator can work.

Key terms

Commissioned translator	مترجم بتكليف	Translates for a client.
Self-initiated translator	مترجم بمبادرة ذاتية	Chooses a text to translate, with no client.
Bicultural	مُلمّ بالثقافتين	Knows both cultures well.

2.1 What a good translator needs

- **Two languages.** Be fluent in both the source and the target language.
- **Two cultures.** Cultural knowledge is as important as language knowledge.
- **General knowledge.** A translator should be like a “walking encyclopedia”.
- **A rich vocabulary** (الخصيلة اللغوية), including idioms and fixed expressions.
- **Practice.** Skill grows with experience and with revising your work.

2.2 Two ways of working

Commissioned translator	Self-initiated translator
A client asks you to translate. You follow the client’s style and policy.	Nobody asks you. You choose the text yourself, for example a poem you love.

A **freelancer** works for clients, so a freelancer is a **commissioned** translator.

2.3 Five good habits

1. Be **faithful** to the meaning (الأمانة).
2. Aim to be accurate, faithful and acceptable to the reader.
3. Remember that translation is **rewriting**: the text must read naturally.
4. **Revise** every translation.
5. Translate everything, including titles and captions.

REMEMBER

- A translator needs two languages **and** two cultures.
- Revise every translation, even your best one.

Chapter 3

Before you translate: the brief

قبل أن تترجم: موجز الترجمة

This chapter shows you what to find out, and what to do, before you start translating.

Key terms

Translation brief	موجز الترجمة	The information you need before you start: client, purpose and audience.
Target audience	الجمهور المستهدف	The people who will read the translation.

3.1 Ask three questions

Question	Why it matters
Who is the client? من هو العميل؟	Each client has its own style and policy.
What is the purpose? ما الغرض؟	Is the text meant to inform, persuade, instruct or entertain?
Who is the audience? من هو الجمهور؟	Experts or the general public? Adults or children?

3.2 Prepare in five steps

1. **Read the whole text twice** before you translate.
2. **Highlight** difficult words, idioms and names.
3. **Research** the topic.
4. **Make a list** of the key terms (Chapter 14).
5. **Picture a first draft** in your mind.

3.3 An example brief

Text	A short news report
Client	KUNA (Kuwait News Agency)
Purpose	To inform
Audience	English readers interested in Kuwait
So...	Use a formal, neutral style and keep the headline short.

REMEMBER

- No brief, no plan: find out the **client, purpose and audience** first.
- Never start translating before you have read the whole text.

Chapter 4

English and Arabic are different

الفروق بين الإنجليزية والعربية

This chapter compares the two languages, so that you can avoid the most common problems.

Key terms

Verbal sentence	الجملة الفعلية	A sentence that starts with a verb.
Register	المستوى اللغوي	How formal or informal the language is.
Modern Standard Arabic	الفصحى المعاصرة	The Arabic of newspapers, laws and education.

4.1 The main differences

	English	Arabic
Word order	Subject first: <i>Sam ate the cake.</i>	Verb first: أكلَ سامٌ الكعكةَ
Sentences	Short, with full stops	Long, joined with و، ف، ثمَّ
The verb “is”	Always written	Often not written, or يُعدّ
Synonyms	One word is enough	Pairs add emphasis: شجاعٌ مغوارٌ
Punctuation	, ; ?	، ؟ ،

4.2 Which Arabic?

Use **Modern Standard Arabic** for written translation. Use a dialect (العامية) only if the client asks for it, for example in film subtitles.

4.3 Small words, big traps EN → AR

English	Arabic	Why
<i>He is in bed.</i>	إنه نائم	It means “asleep”, not في السرير.
<i>As an officer, I...</i>	بصفتي ضابطاً...	Here <i>as</i> means a role, not ك.
<i>Translation is a fascinating field.</i>	تعدّ الترجمة مجالاً شائقاً	Start with a verb.
<i>...to see the Roman ruins</i>	لزيارة الآثار الرومانية	Arabic says “visit”.

4.4 Linking words EN → AR

Arabic joins ideas more than English does. These linking words help your Arabic flow:

English	Arabic	English	Arabic
<i>however</i>	غير أنّ	<i>therefore</i>	لذلك
<i>in addition</i>	بالإضافة إلى ذلك	<i>for example</i>	على سبيل المثال
<i>on the other hand</i>	من ناحيةٍ أخرى	<i>as a result</i>	ونتيجةً لذلك

4.5 Numbers

With numbers from 3 to 10, the number takes the **opposite gender** to the noun: ثلاثة طلابٍ but ثلاثُ طالباتٍ.

REMEMBER

- **EN → AR:** start with the verb and join short sentences.
- **AR → EN:** start with the subject, drop repeated synonyms and split long sentences.
- Use Arabic punctuation in Arabic texts: ؟ ، ؛

Chapter 5

Meaning, form and context

المعنى والبناء والسياق

This chapter explains the most important rule in translation: meaning comes before form.

Key terms

Form	البناء	The structure of the words: word, phrase, sentence.
Meaning	المعنى	The idea that the words express.
Denotation	المعنى المعجمي	The basic dictionary meaning.
Connotation	المعنى الإيحائي	The feeling a word carries: positive, negative, respectful.
Context	السياق	The words and situation around a text.

5.1 Meaning comes before form

You may change the **structure** of a sentence, but you must never change its **meaning** (المعنى أهم من البناء).

English	Arabic	Why
<i>Blair, Bush's poodle</i>	بلير، تابع بوش	"Poodle" has no political meaning in Arabic, so we keep the idea: "an obedient follower".
<i>He is a heavy smoker.</i>	يدخن بشراهة	The adjective becomes a verb, and the meaning stays the same.

5.2 Same meaning, different feeling

Word	Feeling
die مات	Neutral
pass away توفي	Respectful
kill اغتال · assassinate قتل	"Assassinate" is political
friend صديق · comrade رفيق	"Comrade" means a member of the same party

5.3 What the speaker really means

Sometimes a speaker means more than the words say:

Words	Real meaning
أشعرُ بالحرّ	"Please turn on the air conditioning."
It's freezing in here.	"Please close the window."

5.4 Context tells you which meaning

Many words have more than one meaning. The **context** tells you which one is correct (لكلّ مقام مقال).

Word	Meanings
bank	ضفّة النهر (a river bank) · مصرف (a financial bank)
عين	an eye · a water spring · a spy
case	علبة (a box) · حالة (in medicine) · قضية (in court)

REMEMBER

- Change the form if you need to, but **never** change the meaning.
- Check the **connotation**, not only the dictionary meaning.
- Let the **context** decide which meaning is correct.

Chapter 6

Analysing the text

تحليل النص

This chapter shows you how to study a text carefully before you translate it.

Key terms

Text analysis	تحليل النص	Studying a text before translating it.
Genre	الجنس النصي	The type of text: news, contract, poem, advert...
Tone	النبرة	The writer's attitude: neutral, critical, friendly...

6.1 Why analyse first?

- You understand the text better with every reading.
- You can find the difficult parts in advance.
- You can choose your strategies before you start.
- You can decide which resources you need.

6.2 Analysis is not a summary

Analysis	Summary
Describes the text: who wrote it, for whom, why, and how.	Only says what the text is about.

When you are asked to analyse, do **not** summarise.

6.3 Ten analysis questions

Answer these questions for every new text. The example answers are for a short KUNA news report.

Question	Example answer
1. Who wrote it, and who published it?	A KUNA reporter; KUNA
2. Who is the client?	KUNA's English service
3. What is the purpose?	To inform
4. Who is the audience?	Readers interested in Kuwait
5. What is the genre?	A news report
6. What is the field?	Politics
7. What are the tone and style?	Neutral and formal
8. Which terms need checking?	Official titles
9. Are there any cultural items?	Forms of address
10. Which strategies and resources will I use?	Mostly literal; a news-style guide

A blank copy of these questions is on the worksheet page at the back of the book.

REMEMBER

- Analyse **before** you translate.
- Your translation must match your analysis: if you call the tone formal, keep it formal.

Chapter 7

Equivalence

التكافؤ

This chapter explains how to find the target-language expression that matches the source.

Key terms

Equivalence	التكافؤ	A TL expression that matches the SL expression.
Formal equivalence	التكافؤ الشكلي	Keeps the form of the original.
Functional equivalence	التكافؤ الوظيفي	Keeps the function , using a TL expression that does the same job.
Ideational equivalence	التكافؤ الفكري	Keeps only the basic idea , in plain words.

7.1 One sentence, three choices

The agreement has remained a dead letter since then.

Type	Arabic	Result
Formal	ظَلَّتْ الاتفاقية حَرْفاً ميتاً منذ ذلك الحين	Same image, but unclear to readers
Functional	ظَلَّتْ الاتفاقية حبراً على ورق منذ ذلك الحين	✓ A familiar Arabic idiom
Ideational	لم تُطَبَّقْ الاتفاقية منذ ذلك الحين	Clear, but the image is lost

7.2 More examples

English	Functional	Ideational
<i>Ali is second to none in poetry.</i>	عليٌّ لا يُشَقُّ له غبار في الشعر	عليٌّ شاعرٌ متميزٌ

REMEMBER

- If the form does not work, keep the **function**.
- If no idiom fits, keep the **idea**.

Chapter 8

Collocations and idioms

التلازم اللفظي والتعابير الاصطلاحية

This chapter explains word partners and fixed expressions, which must never be translated word by word.

Key terms

Collocation	التلازم اللفظي	Words that naturally go together, like <i>strong tea</i> .
Idiom	التعبير الاصطلاحي	A fixed expression whose meaning is not the sum of its words.
Proverb	المثل	A traditional saying.

8.1 Collocations EN → AR

English	Arabic	Not
<i>pay attention</i>	يُنْتَبِه	يدفع الانتباه
<i>pay a visit</i>	يقوم بزيارة	يدفع زيارة
<i>strong tea</i>	شاي ثقيل	شاي قوي
<i>a fast colour</i>	لون ثابت	لون سريع
<i>a close friend</i>	صديق مقرب	

8.2 Collocations AR → EN

Arabic	English
يساورني القلق	<i>I am growing worried</i>
قدّم استقالته	<i>he resigned</i>
اتَّخَذَ قراراً	<i>made a decision</i>
عقد اجتماعاً	<i>held a meeting</i>

8.3 Idioms EN → AR

English	Arabic
<i>It's raining cats and dogs.</i>	تمطر بغزارة
<i>over the moon</i>	يطير من الفرح
<i>to spill the beans</i>	أفشى السرّ
<i>I'm all ears.</i>	كلّي آذان صاغية
<i>Break a leg!</i>	بالتوفيق!
<i>It has been a long day.</i>	كان يوماً شاقّاً

8.4 Proverbs AR → EN

Arabic	English
كالمستجير من الرمضاء بالنار	<i>out of the frying pan into the fire</i>
رجع بخفي حنين	<i>he came back empty-handed</i>
عصفور في اليد خير من عشرة على الشجرة	<i>a bird in the hand is worth two in the bush</i>
لكلّ مقام مقال	<i>there is a time and a place for everything</i>

REMEMBER

- Learn words **with their partners**.
- Never translate an idiom word by word, but check first that it really is an idiom in this context.

Chapter 9

Literal and free translation

الترجمة الحرفية والترجمة الحرة

This chapter compares staying close to the source with moving closer to the reader.

Key terms

Literal translation	الترجمة الحرفية	Keeps the words and changes only the grammar.
Free translation	الترجمة الحرة	Keeps the message, but not the form.
Communicative translation	الترجمة التواصلية	Aims to sound natural to the reader.

9.1 Literal translation: sometimes right, sometimes wrong

English	Arabic	Result
<i>The book is on the table.</i>	الكتاب على الطاولة	✓ Works
<i>to play a role</i>	يلعب دوراً	✓ Works
<i>to pay a visit</i>	يدفع زيارة	✗ Use يقوم بزيارة
<i>a long day</i>	يوم طويل	✗ Use يوم شاق

9.2 Free translation: not too free

English	Free translation	Result
<i>Appointing new staff should be based on equal opportunity.</i>	يجب أن يتم تعيين الموظفين الجدد بعيداً عن المحسوبية والواسطة	✓ Same message
<i>We have had heavy rainfall this winter.</i>	سيكون لدينا موسم زراعي مبشر	✗ Adds a new idea

9.3 Other types of translation

Type	What it means
Sight translation	Reading a written text aloud in another language
Interpreting	Translating speech, during or after the speaker
Subtitling	Translating film dialogue within time and space limits
Localisation	Adapting websites and apps for another country

REMEMBER

- Use literal translation only when the result is natural.
- Free translation may change the form, but not the message.

Chapter 10

The seven translation procedures

إجراءات الترجمة السبعة

This chapter presents seven techniques for translating words and phrases, from the closest to the source to the freest.

These seven procedures were described by Vinay and Darbelnet. Procedures 1–3 stay **close** to the source. Procedures 4–7 move **further** away, and you use them when a close translation sounds wrong.

	Procedure	What it does	Example
1	Borrowing الاقتراض	Take the word as it is.	<i>computer</i> → كمبيوتر
2	Calque النسخ	Translate each part of the expression.	<i>skyscraper</i> → ناطحة سحاب
3	Literal translation الترجمة الحرفية	Translate word for word, when this is correct.	<i>The book is on the table.</i> → الكتاب على الطاولة
4	Transposition الإبدال	Change the word class, e.g. noun → verb.	<i>after his arrival</i> → بعد أن وصل
5	Modulation التحوير	Change the point of view.	<i>It is not difficult.</i> → إنه سهل
6	Equivalence التكافؤ	Use a completely different fixed expression.	<i>Like father, like son.</i> → هذا الشبل من ذاك الأسد
7	Adaptation التكييف	Replace a cultural situation with a familiar one.	<i>like Romeo and Juliet</i> → كقيسٍ وليلى

1–3 = direct procedures · 4–7 = oblique procedures

10.1 The procedures in one sentence

After his arrival in Kuwait, the minister held a press conference at the Sheraton and said the reforms were not impossible.

بعد أن وصل الوزير إلى الكويت، عقد مؤتمراً صحفياً في فندق شيراتون، وقال إن الإصلاحات ممكنة.

English	Arabic	Procedure
<i>after his arrival</i>	بعد أن وصل	Transposition (noun → verb)
<i>press conference</i>	مؤتمر صحفي	Calque
<i>Sheraton</i>	شيراتون	Borrowing
<i>not impossible</i>	ممكنة	Modulation

10.2 Why learn the names?

When you write a commentary (Chapter 17), you can **name** the procedure you used and explain why. For example: *“After his arrival” was changed into a verb because Arabic prefers verbs.*

REMEMBER

- Start with procedures 1–3.
- Move to 4–7 when the result sounds unnatural or unclear.

Chapter 11

Translation strategies

استراتيجيات الترجمة

This chapter gives you practical solutions for words and expressions that have no direct equivalent.

Key terms

Strategy

الاستراتيجية

A planned solution to a translation problem.

11.1 Six useful strategies

Strategy	Use it when...	Example
Functional translation الترجمة الوظيفية	a TL expression does the same job	<i>spill the beans</i> → أفشى السرّ
Cultural substitution الإبدال الثقافي	a cultural reference would mean nothing to the reader	<i>Romeo and Juliet</i> → قيس وليلى
Addition الإضافة	the reader needs extra information (common EN → AR)	<i>the Fed</i> → مجلس الاحتياطي الفيدرالي الأمريكي
Omission الحذف	words repeat the same meaning (common AR → EN)	شجاعٌ مغوار → <i>very brave</i>
A more general word اللفظ الأعم	the TL has no exact word	<i>prawns / shrimps</i> → روبيان
Borrowing + explanation الاقتراض مع الشرح	a cultural word must be kept	الوقف → <i>waqf</i> (a charitable endowment)

Never add information to headlines, and never omit real information.

11.2 Translating metaphors

A **metaphor** (الاستعارة) compares two things without “as” or “like”: *She is a moon*. A **simile** (التشبيه) uses “as” or “like”. Follow these four steps, in order:

Step	Example
1. Keep the image if both languages share it.	<i>She is a snake.</i> → إنها أفعى
2. Use an Arabic image if the English one is unfamiliar.	<i>the tip of the iceberg</i> → غيض من فيض
3. Change it into a simile.	<i>He is a rock.</i> → إنه كالصخرة في ثباته
4. Give the plain meaning (the last option).	<i>He is a chicken.</i> → إنه جبان

11.3 Domestication and foreignisation

Domestication (التوطين) makes the text feel local to the reader. **Foreignisation** (التغريب) keeps its foreign flavour. For example, *the diwaniya* (foreignised) or *a men’s evening gathering* (domesticated).

REMEMBER

- Choose a strategy for each problem, not for the whole text.
- For metaphors: keep the image, replace it, turn it into a simile, or explain it, in that order.

Chapter 12

Culture in translation

الثقافة في الترجمة

This chapter explains how to translate expressions that belong to one culture.

Key terms

Cultural approximation	التقريب الثقافي	Bringing cultural meaning as close as possible to the TL reader.
Culture-specific item	عنصر ثقافي خاص	A word or custom that belongs to one culture.

12.1 Expressions EN → AR

English	Arabic
<i>I've got the test in the bag.</i>	الامتحان في جيبي
<i>cut from the same cloth</i>	من طينة واحدة
<i>a scapegoat</i>	كبش الفداء
<i>like mother, like daughter</i>	أقلب الجرة على فيها تطلع البنت لأُمّها

12.2 When climate changes meaning

English	Arabic	Why
<i>The news warmed my heart.</i>	أثلج الخبر صدري	In a hot climate, relief feels cold .

Shakespeare wrote: “*Shall I compare thee to a summer’s day?*” An English summer is mild and lovely, but a Gulf summer is harsh, so many translators choose spring: **أشبهك بيوم ربيعي؟**

12.3 Titles and institutions

English	Arabic
<i>the Home Office</i> (UK)	وزارة الداخلية
<i>the Secretary of State</i> (US)	وزير الخارجية
<i>the Chancellor of the Exchequer</i> (UK)	وزير المالية
<i>the Secretary of the Treasury</i> (US)	وزير الخزانة

12.4 Social expressions

Translate greetings and condolences with the phrase people actually use **in the same situation**:

English	Arabic	Situation
<i>I'm sorry for your loss.</i>	عظم الله أجركم	Condolence
<i>Welcome! It's an honour.</i>	أهلاً وسهلاً، شرفتمونا	Hospitality
<i>Thank you for your hard work.</i>	الله يعطيك العافية	Thanks
<i>Many happy returns!</i>	عساكم من عَوَّاده	Gulf festive greeting

REMEMBER

- Translate the **effect**, not the image.
- Use the expression a TL speaker would use in the same situation.

Chapter 13

When there is no equivalent

عندما لا يوجد مقابل

This chapter shows two solutions for words that have no equivalent: describing them, and creating new words.

Key terms

Descriptive translation	الترجمة الوصفية	Explaining a word by describing its meaning.
Lexical creation	التحت المعجمي	Creating a new word in the TL.
Transliteration	النقل الصوتي	Writing the sounds of a word in the other alphabet.

13.1 Describe the word

For cultural and religious words, first **transliterate** the word, then **describe** it in brackets or in a footnote. Do this only the first time the word appears.

Arabic	English
الزكاة	<i>zakat</i> (obligatory almsgiving in Islam)
التيّم	<i>tayammum</i> (ritual washing with clean earth when there is no water)
البسملة	<i>the basmala</i> (saying “In the name of God, the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful”)
العدّة	<i>‘idda</i> (the waiting period before a divorced or widowed woman may remarry)

This is the **last option**, because it makes the text longer.

13.2 Create a new word

Method	Example
New word	<i>blog</i> → مدوّنة
Translate each part (calque)	<i>smartphone</i> → الهاتف الذكي
Borrow the sounds	<i>radio</i> → راديو
Mix both	<i>cybersecurity</i> → الأمن السيبراني
Short explanation	<i>jet lag</i> → إرهاق السفر

13.3 New words in the news

English	Arabic
<i>greenwashing</i>	التضليل البيئي
<i>cancel culture</i>	ثقافة الإلغاء
<i>global warming</i>	الاحترار العالمي

Search before you create. An accepted word from the Arabic language academies or UNTERM is always better than a new invention.

REMEMBER

- Describe only the first time a word appears.
- Look for an existing term before you create a new one.

Chapter 14

Terminology

المصطلحات

This chapter shows you how to find, check and record specialised terms.

Key terms

Term	المصطلح	A word with a special meaning in one field, e.g. law or medicine.
Term list	قائمة المصطلحات	A table of approved terms for a project.

14.1 Four steps

1. **Find** the key terms in the text.
2. **Check** them in reliable sources.
3. **Record** each term and its context.
4. **Share** the list, so the whole team uses the same terms.

14.2 A simple term list

English term	Arabic term	Field	Note
<i>governing law</i>	القانون الواجب التطبيق	Legal	Not القانون الحاكم
<i>provided that</i>	شريطة أن	Legal	Contract condition
<i>Article (of a law)</i>	مادة	Legal	A contract <i>clause</i> = بند
<i>greenwashing</i>	التضليل البيئي	Environment	Also الغسل الأخضر

Where to check Arabic terms: UNTERM (United Nations), Arabterm, the Arabic language academies, and the client's own glossary.

REMEMBER

- Use **one term for one idea** throughout the text.
- Do not change a term “for variety”: a new word suggests a new meaning.

Chapter 15

Revising your translation

مراجعة الترجمة

This chapter shows you how to check your translation and avoid the most common mistakes.

Key terms

Revision

المراجعة

Checking a translation against the source and correcting it.

15.1 Revise in three readings

1. **Accuracy reading**, with the source text: is anything missing, added or changed?
2. **Fluency reading**, without the source text: does it sound natural?
3. **Final check**: numbers, names, punctuation, titles and captions.

15.2 Common mistakes in Arabic EN → AR

Mistake	Wrong X	Right ✓
Subject first	الحكومة أعلنت...	أعلنت الحكومة...
Overusing قام به	قام الوزير بزيارة الكويت	زار الوزير الكويت
Passive with من قبل	تم افتتاح المعرض من قبل الوزير	افتتح الوزير المعرض
Numbers 3–10	ثلاث طلاب	ثلاثة طلاب
Spelling	إنشاء • مدرسه • الى	إنشاء • مدرسة • إلى
Punctuation	نعم، شكراً؟	نعم، شكراً!

15.3 Common mistakes in English AR → EN

Mistake	Wrong ✗	Right ✓
Very long sentences	<i>...and he said and he added and...</i>	Split them with full stops.
Repeated synonyms	<i>brave and daring</i>	<i>very brave</i>
Extra “the”	<i>The life is beautiful.</i>	<i>Life is beautiful.</i>
Missing verb “to be”	<i>He in the office.</i>	<i>He is in the office.</i>
Arabic preposition	<i>He married from her.</i>	<i>He married her.</i>
No capital letters	<i>the minister of health</i>	<i>the Minister of Health</i>

15.4 Post-editing

Post-editing (التحرير اللاحق) means correcting a machine translation. It is now an important part of the translator’s work (Chapter 20).

REMEMBER

- Read your translation once **without** the source text.
- If a sentence sounds translated, rewrite it.

Chapter 16

Spotting risks

تقييم المخاطر

This chapter helps you find the places where a translation mistake could cause real harm.

Key terms

Risk

الخطر

The chance that a translation choice causes a problem.

Before you deliver a translation, look for these risky places:

Risk	Example	What to do
Wrong term	<i>governing law</i> → القانون الحاكم	Check a specialised dictionary
Lost “not”	A negative sentence becomes positive	Compare sentence by sentence
Cultural image	<i>warmed my heart</i> → أدفأ قلبي	Use cultural approximation
Sensitive names	<i>Persian Gulf / Arabian Gulf</i>	Follow the client; mention it in your commentary
Legal words	<i>shall</i> → سوف	Use the Arabic present tense
Numbers and dates	Wrong figure, Hijri or Gregorian date	Check every number
Wrong style	A dialect word in a formal report	Re-read with the brief in mind
Unclear word	علم: flag, knowledge or taught?	Read the words around it

The more **serious** the possible harm, the more carefully you should check, for example by asking a second person to review your translation.

REMEMBER

- Check numbers, names, negatives and legal words every time.
- When a risk is high, ask a second person to check.

Chapter 17

Writing a commentary

كتابة التعليق على الترجمة

This chapter shows you how to explain and justify your translation choices.

Key terms

Commentary

التعليق على الترجمة

A short text that explains the problems in a translation and justifies the solutions.

17.1 Five parts for each problem

Part	Question
1. Problem	What was difficult?
2. Solution	What did you write?
3. Strategy	Which strategy or procedure did you use?
4. Resource	Which dictionary or source did you check?
5. Justification	Why is your choice right?

17.2 An example

The ST says the agreement “remained a dead letter”. A literal translation, حرفاً ميتاً, would confuse Arab readers, so the translator chose حبراً على ورق. This is a **functional equivalent**. It was checked in Arabic newspapers. It is a familiar idiom and suits the formal style of the news report.

17.3 Rules

- Write in the **third person**: “The translator...”
- **Quote** examples and **name** the strategy.
- Always explain **why**.

REMEMBER

- Problem → solution → strategy → resource → justification.

Chapter 18

Language and ideology

اللغة والأيدولوجيا

This chapter explains how word choices can show a point of view, and what a translator should do about it.

Key terms

Ideology	الأيدولوجيا	A set of beliefs that affects how events are described.
Discourse analysis	تحليل الخطاب	Studying how language shows power and ideology.

18.1 No word is neutral

Word choices can show a point of view. Your translation can keep, soften or strengthen it.

English	Arabic	Note
<i>regime · government</i>	نظام · حكومة	“Regime” is negative
<i>suicide bomber</i>	انتحاري / استشهادي	The choice depends on the client’s policy
<i>Protesters were killed.</i>	قُتل متظاهرون	The passive hides who did it

18.2 Three levels (Fairclough)

Norman Fairclough looks at every text on three levels:

Level	Ask
1. The text	Which words show judgement? Who is the doer?
2. Its production	Who wrote it, and for which newspaper or organisation?
3. Society	Whose interests does it serve?

REMEMBER

- Notice loaded words.
- Follow the client’s policy, and explain your choice in the commentary.

Chapter 19

Dictionaries

المعاجم

This chapter shows you which dictionaries to use and how to use them well.

Key terms

Bilingual dictionary	معجم ثنائي اللغة	Gives equivalents in another language.
Monolingual dictionary	معجم أحادي اللغة	Explains words in the same language.

19.1 Useful dictionaries

Dictionary	Use it for
Al-Mawrid (English–Arabic, Arabic–English)	Everyday words in both directions
Hans Wehr, <i>A Dictionary of Modern Written Arabic</i>	Arabic words, organised by root
Al-Mu‘jam al-Wasīṭ المعجم الوسيط	Checking Arabic meanings
Oxford Collocations Dictionary	Finding natural English word partners
Online dictionaries (e.g. Almaany)	Quick searches. Always double-check them.
UNTERM, Arabterm	Official and technical terms

19.2 The three-check rule

1. Find options in a **bilingual** dictionary.
2. Confirm the meaning in a **monolingual** dictionary.
3. Check real use in a **text written in the TL**.

Example: for *fast colour*, a bilingual dictionary gives ثابت سريع. An Arabic dictionary confirms that لون ثابت means “does not fade”. So the answer is لون ثابت.

REMEMBER

- Never take the first meaning a dictionary gives.
- Check in a bilingual dictionary, then a monolingual one, then a real text.

Chapter 20

Machine translation and AI

الترجمة الآلية والذكاء الاصطناعي

This chapter explains how to use machine translation and AI tools safely.

Key terms

Machine translation	الترجمة الآلية	Translation done by software, such as Google Translate or AI chat tools.
Post-editing	التحرير اللاحق	A human correcting machine translation.
Hallucination	الهلوسة	AI output that is not in the source, such as an invented fact.

20.1 Useful or risky?

Useful for	Risky for
A first draft of simple texts	Legal, medical and religious texts
Checking ideas	Idioms and poetry
Large amounts of text	Private or confidential texts

20.2 Typical machine mistakes

English	Machine ✗	Correct ✓
<i>It's raining cats and dogs.</i>	إنها تمطر قططاً وكلاباً	تمطر بغزارة
<i>The doctor said she...</i>	قال الطبيب...	قالت الطبيبة...

20.3 Four rules

1. **You are responsible** for every word, whatever tool you use.
2. Never put a client's **private text** into a public AI tool.
3. **Check** terms, names, numbers, idioms and every “not”.
4. **Tell the client** if you used a machine or AI.

REMEMBER

- Machine translation is a first draft, not a final translation.

Chapter 21

Text types (genres)

أجناس النصوص

This chapter shows what matters most when translating the main types of text.

Key terms

Genre	الجنس النصي	A familiar type of text with its own rules.
Genre	What matters	Example
News	Facts, neutral tone, short headlines	<i>Oil prices rose sharply on Monday.</i> ارتفعت أسعار النفط ارتفاعاً حاداً يوم الاثنين.
Legal	Exact words; <i>shall</i> means an obligation	<i>This Agreement shall be governed by the laws of the State of Kuwait.</i> تخضع هذه الاتفاقية لقوانين دولة الكويت.
Political	Careful, sensitive words	<i>The two sides held frank and constructive talks.</i> أجرى الجانبان محادثات صريحة وبناءة.
Medical	No ambiguity; exact doses	<i>Take one tablet twice daily.</i> تناول قرصاً واحداً مرتين يومياً.
Technical	Clear instructions, consistent terms	<i>Press and hold the power button.</i> اضغط مطوّلاً على زرّ التشغيل.
Literary	Feeling, voice, natural dialogue	<i>It has been a long day.</i> كان يوماً شاقّاً.
Poetry	Images, rhythm; more freedom	<i>الخيّلُ والليلُ والبيداءُ تعرفني</i> (al-Mutanabbi) <i>The horses, the night and the desert know me</i>
Advertising	Persuasion and rhythm	<i>Save more. Smile more.</i> وفر أكثر... وابّسم أكثر!

REMEMBER

- Identify the genre **before** you translate: each genre has its own rules.

Exercises

Practice

التمارين

The exercises get longer and harder, level by level. The chapter number after each sentence tells you where to look for help. Answers start on p. 40.

Level 1 Sentences

A. Translate each sentence. EN → AR

- | | | |
|---|--|--------|
| 1 | <i>She paid a visit to her grandmother.</i> | Ch. 8 |
| 2 | <i>The agreement has remained a dead letter.</i> | Ch. 7 |
| 3 | <i>He is a heavy smoker.</i> | Ch. 10 |
| 4 | <i>It's raining cats and dogs.</i> | Ch. 8 |
| 5 | <i>The Home Office issued a statement.</i> | Ch. 12 |

B. Translate each sentence. AR → EN

- | | | |
|----|-----------------------------|--------|
| 6 | رجع بخفي حنين. | Ch. 8 |
| 7 | أثلج الخبر صدري. | Ch. 12 |
| 8 | هو شجاع مغوار. | Ch. 11 |
| 9 | يساورني القلق بشأن النتائج. | Ch. 8 |
| 10 | قدم الوزير استقالته أمس. | Ch. 4 |

C. Each translation has one mistake. Find it and correct it.

- | | | |
|----|--|--------|
| 11 | <i>Pay attention, please.</i> → ادفع الانتباه من فضلك. | Ch. 8 |
| 12 | <i>The government announced new measures.</i> → الحكومة أعلنت إجراءات جديدة. | Ch. 4 |
| 13 | <i>I have three brothers.</i> → لدي ثلاث إخوة. | Ch. 4 |
| 14 | <i>The life is beautiful.</i> → الحياة جميلة. | Ch. 15 |

15 تزوّج منها العام الماضي. → *He married from her last year.*

Ch. 15

Level 2 Short texts

For each text: (1) write the brief (client, purpose, audience), (2) translate it, and (3) write two sentences explaining your main choice.

Text 2a EN → AR

All human beings are born free and equal in dignity and rights. They are endowed with reason and conscience and should act towards one another in a spirit of brotherhood.

Universal Declaration of Human Rights (United Nations, 1948), Article 1. When you have finished, compare your version with the official Arabic text.

Text 2b AR → EN

الخيْلُ والليلُ والبيداءُ تعرفني .
والسيفُ والرمحُ والقرطاسُ والقلمُ

al-Mutanabbi (d. 965 CE). Keep the rhythm of the list.

Text 2c EN → AR

*Shall I compare thee to a summer's day?
Thou art more lovely and more temperate.*

Shakespeare, Sonnet 18 (1609). Summer or spring? Explain your choice (Chapter 12).

Level 3 Full texts

Work through all the steps, as a professional would:

1. Answer the ten analysis questions (Chapter 6).
2. Translate the text.
3. Revise it using the checklists on p. 42.
4. Write a short commentary of about 150 words (Chapter 17).

Text 3a • News EN → AR

Health officials have urged residents to stay indoors between 11 a.m. and 4 p.m. as temperatures are expected to top 50°C this week. “Heatstroke is not something to take lightly,” a Ministry of Health spokesperson said, advising people to drink plenty of water and to check on elderly neighbours. Meanwhile, shopping malls are expected to be packed as families seek relief from the heat.

Practice text written for this handbook.

Text 3b • Cultural news AR → EN

احتفلت الجمعية الثقافية مساء أمس بتكريم نخبة من المترجمين الشباب، وذلك في أمسية حضرها لفيف من الأدباء والأكاديميين. وأكد رئيس الجمعية في كلمته أنّ الترجمة جسر يصل الشعوب بعضها ببعض، مشيراً إلى أنّ العناية بالمترجمين الشباب واجب لا ترف. واختتمت الأمسية بقراءات شعرية مترجمة، وسط أجواء سادها الودّ والتقدير.

Practice text written for this handbook.

Answers

الإجابات

These are suggested answers. Often there is more than one good translation: any version that is accurate, natural and right for the reader is acceptable.

Level 1 Sentences

#	Suggested answer	Why
1	زارت جدّتها.	"Pay a visit" simply means "visit".
2	ظَلَّت الاتفاقية حبراً على ورق.	A functional equivalent (Chapter 7).
3	يدخّن بشرافة.	Transposition: the adjective becomes a verb.
4	تمطر بغزارة.	An idiom is never translated word by word.
5	أصدرت وزارة الداخلية البريطانية بياناً.	The Home Office is the interior ministry.
6	<i>He came back empty-handed.</i>	The proverb's meaning, in natural English.
7	<i>The news warmed my heart.</i>	Arabic "cold" relief becomes English "warmth".
8	<i>He is very brave.</i>	English does not need two synonyms.
9	<i>I am growing worried about the results.</i>	A natural English collocation.
10	<i>The minister resigned yesterday.</i>	Subject first; قدّم استقالته = "resigned".
11	انتبه من فضلك.	Collocation
12	أعلنت الحكومة إجراءاتٍ جديدة.	Start with the verb.
13	لديّ ثلاثة إخوة.	Numbers 3–10 take the opposite gender.
14	<i>Life is beautiful.</i>	No "the" before general ideas.
15	<i>He married her last year.</i>	No Arabic preposition in English.

Level 2 Short texts

يُولد جميعُ الناس أحراراً ومتساوين في الكرامة والحقوق، وقد وهبوا العقلَ والضميرَ، وعليهم أن يعامل 2a. بعضهم بعضاً بروح الإخاء.

Start with the verb (يُولد) and join the two sentences with و. Then compare with the official UN Arabic text.

2b. *The horses, the night and the desert know me, as do the sword, the spear, the paper and the pen.*

Keep the list of seven nouns. *Steed* and *parchment* would give a more classical tone.

2c. أَشْبَهَكَ يَوْمٌ مِنْ أَيَّامِ الرَّبِيعِ؟ أَنْتِ أُمِّهِ مِنْهُ وَأَكْثَرُ اعْتِدَالاً.

Spring gives Arab readers the same pleasant feeling that summer gives English readers (Chapter 12).

Level 3 Tips

3a. *top 50°C* → 50 درجة مئوية · *not something to take lightly* → أمرٌ خطير (modulation) · *check on* → الاطمئنان على · *packed* → مكتظة

3b. Suggested opening: *Last night, the Cultural Society honoured a group of outstanding young translators at an evening attended by writers and academics.* Split the long sentence, keep the “bridge” image, and translate *الودّ والتقدير* as *a warm, appreciative atmosphere*.

Checklists

قوائم التحقق

Use these checklists with every translation. Tick each point as you go.

Before you translate

- ☐ I know the **client**, the **purpose** and the **audience**.
- ☐ I have read the whole text **twice**.
- ☐ I know the **genre** and the **tone**.
- ☐ I have marked difficult words, idioms, names and cultural items.
- ☐ I have made a list of **key terms**.
- ☐ I have my dictionaries and resources ready.

While you translate

- ☐ The **meaning** is the same as in the source.
- ☐ The **terms** are the same all the way through.
- ☐ The **style** suits the brief (formal or informal).
- ☐ The **collocations** and idioms sound natural.
- ☐ Cultural references are handled.

After you translate

- ☐ Nothing is missing and nothing is added.
- ☐ Every “not” is still there.
- ☐ Grammar, spelling and punctuation are correct.
- ☐ Numbers, names, dates, titles and captions are checked.
- ☐ I have read the translation once **without** the source.

Your commentary

- ☐ For each problem: problem → solution → strategy → resource → justification.
- ☐ I quote examples from the source and the translation.
- ☐ I write in the third person.

Analysis worksheet

ورقة تحليل النص

Photocopy this page and fill it in before you translate a new text (Chapter 6).

Text: _____ Direction: ☐ EN → AR ☐ AR → EN

1. Who wrote it, and who published it?

2. Who is the client?

3. What is the purpose?

4. Who is the audience?

5. What is the genre?

6. What is the field?

7. What are the tone and style?

8. Which terms need checking?

9. Are there any cultural items?

10. Which strategies and resources will I use?

Glossary

مسرد المصطلحات

The key terms in this handbook, in alphabetical order, with the page where each one is explained.

Adaptation	التكييف	Replacing a cultural situation with a familiar one.	20
Addition	الإضافة	Adding words the reader needs.	22
Analysis (text analysis)	تحليل النص	Studying a text before translating it.	13
Approximation	التقريب	Bringing the meaning as close as possible to the TL.	4
Borrowing	الاقتراض	Taking a word from the SL as it is.	20
Calque	النسخ	Translating each part of an expression.	20
Client	العميل	The person or organisation who asks for a translation.	7
Collocation	التلازم اللفظي	Words that naturally go together.	16
Commentary	التعليق على الترجمة	A text that explains and justifies translation choices.	32
Commissioned translator	مترجم بتكليف	A translator who works for a client.	5
Communication	التواصل	Understanding and being understood.	4
Connotation	المعنى الإيحائي	The feeling a word carries.	11
Context	السياق	The words and situation around a text.	11
Cultural approximation	التقريب الثقافي	Bringing cultural meaning close to the TL reader.	24
Cultural substitution	الإبدال الثقافي	Replacing a cultural reference with a TL one.	22
Denotation	المعنى المعجمي	The basic dictionary meaning.	11
Descriptive translation	الترجمة الوصفية	Explaining a word by describing it.	26
Discourse analysis	تحليل الخطاب	Studying how language shows power and ideology.	33

Domestication	التوطين	Making a text feel local to the reader.	22
Equivalence	التكافؤ	A TL expression that matches the SL one.	15
Foreignisation	التغريب	Keeping the foreign flavour of a text.	22
Form	البناء	The structure of words and sentences.	11
Formal equivalence	التكافؤ الشكلي	Keeps the form of the original.	15
Free translation	الترجمة الحرة	Keeps the message, but not the form.	18
Functional equivalence	التكافؤ الوظيفي	Keeps the function of the original.	15
Genre	الجنس النصي	A type of text, e.g. news or a contract.	36
Hallucination	الهلوسة	AI output that is not in the source.	35
Ideational equivalence	التكافؤ الفكري	Keeps only the basic idea.	15
Ideology	الأيدولوجيا	Beliefs that affect how events are described.	33
Idiom	التعبير الاصطلاحي	A fixed expression whose meaning is not the sum of its words.	16
Interpretation	الترجمة الشفهية	Translating speech.	4
Lexical creation	النحت المعجمي	Creating a new word in the TL.	26
Literal translation	الترجمة الحرفية	Keeping the words and changing only the grammar.	18
Machine translation	الترجمة الآلية	Translation done by software.	35
Meaning	المعنى	The idea that words express.	11
Metaphor	الاستعارة	A comparison without “as” or “like”.	22
Modern Standard Arabic	الفصحى المعاصرة	The Arabic of newspapers, laws and education.	9
Modulation	التحوير	Changing the point of view.	20
Omission	الحذف	Leaving out words that repeat the meaning.	22
Post-editing	التحرير اللاحق	A human correcting machine translation.	35
Procedure	الإجراء	A technique for translating a word or phrase.	20
Proverb	المثل	A traditional saying.	16

Register	المستوى اللغوي	How formal the language is.	9
Revision	المراجعة	Checking and correcting a translation.	29
Risk	الخطر	The chance that a choice causes a problem.	31
Self-initiated translator	مترجم بمبادرة ذاتية	A translator who chooses a text, with no client.	5
Simile	التشبيه	A comparison with “as” or “like”.	22
Source language (SL)	اللغة المصدر	The language of the original text.	3
Strategy	الاستراتيجية	A planned solution to a translation problem.	22
Target language (TL)	اللغة الهدف	The language of the translation.	3
Term	المصطلح	A word with a special meaning in one field.	28
Translation	الترجمة التحريرية	Transferring the meaning of a written text.	4
Translation brief	موجز الترجمة	Client, purpose and audience.	7
Transliteration	النقل الصوتي	Writing a word's sounds in the other alphabet.	26
Transposition	الإبدال	Changing the word class, e.g. noun → verb.	20
Verbal sentence	الجملة الفعلية	A sentence that starts with a verb.	9

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المراجع

Team course materials

The Translation Team's course notes and drafts, the **180** textbook and the **182** course book. (Full details to be added.)

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“Translate the meaning, not the words.”

ترجم المعنى، لا الكلمات.

This handbook introduces beginners to translating between English and Arabic, step by step, from preparing to translate to checking and explaining the result. Each chapter follows the same simple layout, with clear examples in both languages and exercises with answers.